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Afghanistan's Impact on Indo-Pakistani Relations

From the dawn of Indian history, the Afghan Plateau has been a springboard to the conquest of India by martial raiders from the West. Indo-Aryan tribes first came down the Khyber and Bolan Passes over the Hindu Kush as early as 1500 B.C.E. Alexander the Great led his Macedonian army over the Khyber, crossing the Indus in 326 B.C.E., followed by Perso-Afghans, Central Asian Scythians, and Kushanas, Turks, and Mughals. The Muslim conquerors of Punjab, Kashmir, Sind, and the North-West Frontier converted Hindus of that region to Islam, or forced them to flee south. Though the British ultimately won control over the entire region, virtually all of the people in what is now called Pakistan remained Muslims. The dominant Pathan tribes of Pakistan's North-West Frontier Province speak the same Pashtun language as their Afghan neighbors and use the same frontier plateau land to graze their goats and sheep as do the Baloch tribes to their south.

Nor were the British ever able to march west over those high passes or long retain control over Afghanistan's capital, Kabul, or its second-largest city, Kandahar. Several arrogant British viceroys and generals thought they had beaten those "wily Pathans," but most never lived to return home.[1] Then, before the end of the nineteenth century, as Russia's empire moved south, the "Great Game" began between tsarist Russia and British India for control of Afghanistan's Hermit Kingdom. Tsar Peter the Great viewed Russia's expansion into Central Asia in 1710 as his "destiny" and "civilizing mission." Subsequent tsars absorbed the Muslim sultanates of Bokhara, Khiva, and Khokand into Russia's